



COURSE REPORT FOR FIRST CYCLE COURSES IN POLITICAL SCIENCE

The aim of the course report is to demonstrate responsiveness towards the students' views, guarantee the quality of the course, and stimulate subject-related and pedagogical development. The report should have a forward-looking focus and be based on the course coordinator's own reflections and input received from students (individually or in groups), teaching staff, education administrators, and the study counsellor, as well as the course evaluation.

Course name:	Institutional Development and Democratization in an International Perspective
Course code:	SK1227
Semester:	Spring 2025
Course coordinator (name and e-mail address):	Nikolay Marinov (nikolay.marinov@gu.se)
Brief description of course content and structure	This course deals with the origins of the state, problems of autocratic rule, the emergence and advantages of democracy, how democracy influences autocracy and vice versa, and what the future might hold.
Completion rate and grades	Number of students registered for the course: 31 registered students Number with final grades 31 G (pass) 6 (20 %) VG (pass with distinction) 25 (80 %) The course was generally perceived as balanced in workload, with most students indicating it was acceptable or not too demanding. However, it was noted that the workload was unevenly distributed throughout the course, which caused stress toward the end. "The organization of the course made it rather unstimulating until the final week, which became very stressful." "The level was good; some weeks were busier than others, but it evened out overall."



General and specific impressions of the course	Many found the content highly interesting, relevant, and rewarding. Several highlighted the instructor's engagement, though there was also criticism of the structure and planning—especially at the start of the course. "Interesting topics, fun teacher, and well-balanced workload." "The course could have been clearer about its focus and what we were expected to take away." "At times, the course lacked a clear thread." "Lots of potential, especially with better structure." "Could have had a more international perspective—too much focus on Eastern Europe."
Students' general impressions of the course	Students appreciated that the course related to current events and that the instructor used news and research in lectures. There were also suggestions for more variety and greater clarity. "I appreciated that Nikolay brought up current news and interesting findings during the lectures."
Students' impressions of specific elements of the course	"It would be interesting to include more perspectives outside Europe, e.g., Asia or Africa." "Good structure with three written assignments, one presentation, and a final exam."
Impression of any epiphany moments that the students have experienced during the course	Many reported gaining new insights, particularly about autocracy, democratization, and global political processes. "The discussion about Eastern Europe and liberation from Russia was an eye-opener." "I've gained a more nuanced understanding of democracy." "How easily someone like Trump can undermine democracy in the U.S." "That it's difficult to influence autocracies from the outside." "I learned a lot about former Soviet states and polarization."



Impressions of students' and teachers' views on the administration of the course, incl. Canvas	Strong criticism was expressed here. Many experienced the course as confusing and poorly organized, especially due to late changes in the schedule, unclear instructions, and a lack of long-term planning. "Many things were unclear and changed during the course (structure, instructions, etc.)." "Canvas and TimeEdit didn't match—hard to plan." "Information about the exam came too late." "It was obvious that it was the teacher's first time running the course." "Seminars and lectures were not updated in time."						
Ideas of potential changes for the next round	Students suggested earlier and clearer information, improved lecture structure (including PowerPoints), and a more even workload distribution. "Provide information earlier and plan long-term." "Make lectures more structured with clearer PowerPoints." "Ensure the course's main theme is clearer from the start." "Clarify which parts of the course are mandatory."						
Ideas of long-term and/or more comprehensive changes	Better organization!						
Other comments	Several students expressed overall appreciation for the course and the instructor despite organizational weaknesses. Nikolay was described as competent, passionate, and helpful. "I think Marinov is a fantastic teacher." "Kind, helpful, and understanding." "I liked him very much personally—he was very supportive." "If the course is better structured, it has great potential to be fantastic." "I learned a lot, and the content was very interesting."						
From the course evaluation question: "Overall, how do you assess the course?"							
	VT25	HT25	VT26	HT26	VT27	HT27	
	1.6						
	Means						



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Note: The survey question was rated on a 1–5 scale, where 1 is best and 5 is worst. Distribution of responses: 1 = Very good ($n = 7$, 41.2%), 2 = Rather good ($n = 9$, 52.9%), 3 = Neither good nor bad ($n = 1$), 4 = Rather bad ($n = 0$), 5 = Bad ($n = 0$). A total of 17 responses were submitted. The mean score was 1.6.